But the Tamils know a rather different sage. To them he is Agathya or Agattiyam, the latter name implying someone who is inward-looking, from *agam*, ‘inside’, and *iyar*, ‘belong to’. But he is still dwarf-like, and he shares other features with the Vedic Agastya, such as his origins in a pitcher and his crossing of the Vindhyas from north to south. However, from the Tamil point of view, the main reason for the sage’s journey south is to restore cosmic balance. Lord Shiva’s wedding to his *shakti* Parvati at his abode on Mount Kailas attracts so many deities that the Himalayas begin to sink, causing the (flat) Earth to tip towards the north. The gods ask Agathya to go south to restore the balance, which he does. But he also takes with him a pitcher of water from the goddess Ganga that contains the Cauvery River. He and his wife Lopamudra then cross the Vindhyas and with the help of the waters of the Cauvery they make the land fertile and habitable by man.

Crucially, in this account Agathya is the bringer not of Sanskrit but the gift of the Tamil language, which Lord Shiva has presented to him to give to the world. He goes on to found and preside over the first Sangam (Cankam), a literary academy or assembly where scholars and poets gather to produce Tamil literature. To this end, he produces the first Tamil grammar, a work entitled *Agathiyam* which is subsequently lost in a great flood which inundates much of the original Tamil country. Agathya is also acknowledged as the founder of Tamil medical studies and martial arts.